Magistrate of Madurai, an all-powerful post he held for sixteen years.

According to local legend, Rous Peter always began his daily round by riding to the temple on horseback to pay his respects, and over time he became a devotee of the goddess. He reduced local taxes and became so popular with the area's inhabitants that when the *Tanjore Division Gazetteer* was updated in 1914 its author noted that 'vernacular ballads are still being sung in his honour'. According to these folk songs, Rous Peter was sleeping in his bungalow when he was woken by a three-year-old girl with three breasts who dragged him by the hand out of his bungalow, whereupon it was struck by lightning and burned to the ground. The girl then ran into the Meenakshi temple and was not seen again.

In gratitude for his deliverance Rous Peter made an offering to the temple in the form of a pair of golden stirrups studded with rubies. Refusing to return to England on retirement, he died in Madurai and, in accordance with his wishes, was buried in the local Christian church but with his face turned towards the Meenakshi temple. In support of this story there is the evidence of the pair of jewel-encrusted golden stirrups, still to be seen in the temple treasury and regularly brought out whenever the *murti* of the goddess Meenakshi is carried in procession through the town.